

An OS for Personal Computing

Let's take a look at the BeOS-inspired Haiku OS.



GNU/Linux has lots of features for the desktop and the server side. However, there are problems with Linux-based operating systems. Being a monolithic kernel, people often find the system becomes unresponsive when using a GNU/Linux system. Another major problem, especially for new users, is choosing between various distributions. They end up installing a distribution that has more apps and services than they actually need (or that their hardware can support) for their day to day use, which also serves to slow down their systems.

This article introduces you to an operating system called Haiku, which serves as a good starting point for aspiring students and those interested in hacking on operating systems.

So what's so special about Haiku? It is a descendant of the popular BeOS. The team

behind BeOS had lots of ideas about making a perfect operating system targeted at personal computers. Unfortunately, it failed miserably due to various reasons.

Haiku is a POSIX-compliant operating system project that started in 2001. It was initially named OpenBeOS since it was heavily inspired by BeOS. Haiku specifically targets the personal computing space, to bring users a clean user interface and a highly responsive kernel.

It took almost nine years to get the first alpha release of the OS out on September 14, 2009.

Some good features of Haiku are listed below:

- A specific focus on personal computing
- A custom kernel designed for responsiveness
- A fully threaded design for great efficiency with a multi-processor/core CPU
- A rich OO (object-oriented) API for faster development